

different result. What different result are we hoping for when we slap another thing we don't need on a credit card? That *this* time the feeling it creates will last? That *this* time its value will last the product's life span? That's not going to happen—ever. When you buy on credit, luster, newness, and novelty will diminish, but the price tag will always get bigger.

Money Mistake: Spending Makes You Happy

THE FIX: GET A HANDLE ON EMOTIONAL SPENDING

Men and women spend too much because it feels good, temporarily. It's not more complicated than that. But as I say over and over again, feelings and money are a toxic combination. If you're bored, lonely, frustrated, or sad, don't go shopping to change your mood. Do anything, in fact, *but* shop. Go for a walk, cook, read, but don't head for the mall.

It's not enough to stanch the flow of funds out; you need to understand why you spend, why you have a tendency to put yourself in precarious financial situations, over and over again—especially if overspending is affecting your health or your relationships. See a specialist in compulsive behavior. Check out a Debtors Anonymous meeting to see if it's for you. And find other pleasures, other pursuits beyond shopping and spending, that give you satisfaction, fulfillment, and joy. Most important, don't hang around other emotional spenders—friends who subtly pressure you to drop half your paycheck on those shoes that look so good on you. Spending can be a contagious disease. If you have a friend who is justifying and enabling your spending problem, at the very least don't shop with that person. And I like this classic bit of advice: Put your cards in containers, cover them with water, and throw them in the freezer. You won't damage the cards, and if you still want to make that purchase twenty-four hours after you let the cards thaw out, fine. But freezing your cards forces you to think it over before you buy. You may also want to limit your exposure to persuasive ads and red-hot deals that constantly assault